PART II · TIME · 8

Repeats and road signs

Music often says “play that again”. Instead of writing the same bars twice, it uses **repeat signs** and **road signs**. Read them like a map: they tell you which bar comes next.

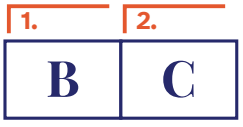
THE SECRET

Follow the map: jump back at the sign, stop at Fine, or jump to the Coda.



You play: A → B → A → B → C

Two dots facing back mean: go back and play it again

SIGN	NAME	WHAT YOU DO
	**repeat signs**	play the bars between them twice (with only the end sign: go back to the start)
	**1st and 2nd time bars**	first time play the 1. bar; after the repeat skip it and play the 2. bar
D.C.	**da capo**	“from the head”: go back to the very beginning
	**D.S.** (dal segno)	“from the sign”: go back to the segno
Fine	**fine**	“the end”: after a D.C. or D.S., stop here
	**coda**	“tail”: at “To Coda”, jump to the coda sign and play the ending

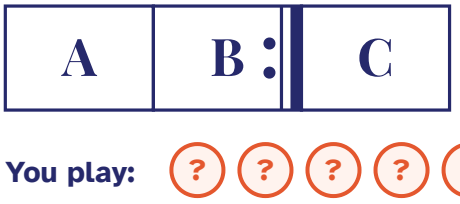
THE RULE

Follow the map in order. At a jump (D.C., D.S.) go back; then the first time you meet Fine, stop; or at To Coda, jump to the coda.

PART II · TIME · 8 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

In what order do you play these bars?

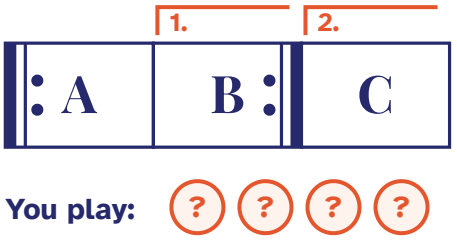


1. **Play A and B.**
2. **B ends with a repeat sign** facing back. There is no start sign: where do you go back to?
3. **Play it again,** then carry on.

Back to the very start: **A B A B C**.

EXAMPLE 2

First and second time



1. **First time through:** play A, then the bar marked 1.
2. **The repeat sign** sends you back to A.
3. **Second time:** which bar do you skip, and which do you play?

A B, A C: **A B A C**. The 1. bar is skipped the second time.

GAME

How many bars do you play?

1

|: A B :|

2

A |: B C :| D

3

A B (Fine) C D.C.

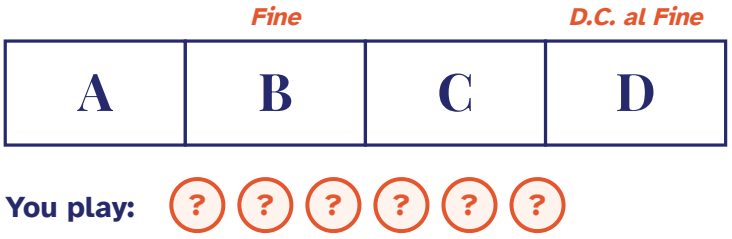
Each letter is one bar. Follow the signs and count every bar you play.

Answer: 1 four (A B A B) · 2 six (A B C B C D) · 3 five (A B C A B).

PART II · TIME · 8 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

D.C. al Fine

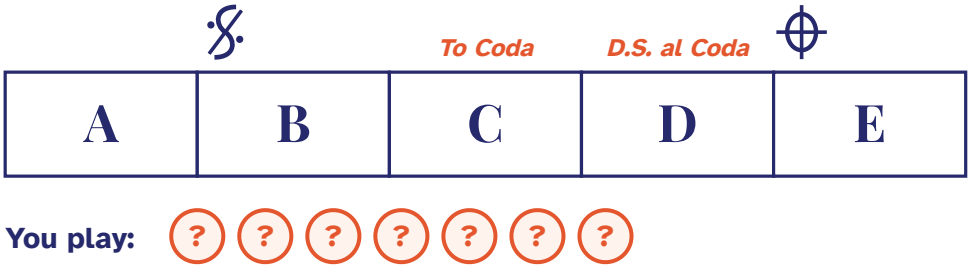


1. **Play straight through** to D.
2. **D.C.** means go back: to where?
3. **al Fine:** where do you stop the second time?

A B C D, then from the head to Fine: **A B C D A B**.

EXAMPLE 4

D.S. al Coda



1. **Play through** to D. (Ignore "To Coda" the first time.)
2. **D.S.** sends you back to the sign: which bar has it?
3. **Play on to "To Coda",** then jump. Where?

A B C D, back to the sign, B C, jump to the coda: **A B C D B C E**.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Clap it, then play it.

Clap A (four beats), clap B (four beats), back to A, B again. Say the letters as you go.

TRAP

- × Taking the repeat again after a D.C.: on the way back, skip the repeats (unless the music says otherwise).
- × Missing "To Coda" the first time through: it only works after the D.S. or D.C.

SEE ALSO

Pulse and the bar p. 47 · Time signatures p. 56

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Signs